

the author does not believe in annotating her work with references and footnotes, it is difficult to ascertain the source of such delightful collections.

If the early chapters of the book make interesting reading, the account rapidly degenerates into a précis of existing accounts laced with Misra's own take on events and personalities. The long narrative on Gandhi, for example, reads like a wide-eyed discovery of the evolution and role of the Mahatma in Indian politics. On the other hand, events such as the Partition are treated almost cursorily in comparison. One is tempted to conclude that the extent of available secondary material had a direct bearing on the quantum of space devoted to the issue. If the volume had eschewed academic pretensions and been shorter, it would have been easier to recommend as a handbook for an expat to read on the plane.

Probably Misra's evident unfamiliarity with the country leads her to commit bloomers that immediately downgrade the effort. For no apparent reason, she titles one of her later chapters "Flames" with reference to *Sholay*, overlooking the correct translation, 'embers'. Worse, she decides that the film's protagonist Jaidev (I thought it was simply Jai) portrays a "low caste character". Having seen *Sholay* at least a dozen times, I cannot recall Jai's caste origin being identified. The author goes on to comment that his caste origin determined he had to die in the movie rather than consummate his love with a high-caste Thakur's daughter-in-law. Then she remarks that Amitabh Bachchan is "physically a far cry from the chiselled perfection supposedly associated with high caste leading men". Further, she asserts he is the son of a "Brahman poet and a society-hostess mother". If only she had spent a few weeks in India, Misra would have known that the late Harivansh Rai is a celebrated Kayasth and his wife Teji not a mere Punjabi socialite.

The final boo-boo takes the cake. On December 13, 2001, the author claims, criticism of the Vajpayee Government reached a peak when a "bomb exploded in the Indian Parliament". That's the point where I thought I would explode if I read any further. Little knowledge, it is appropriately said, is dangerous. ■

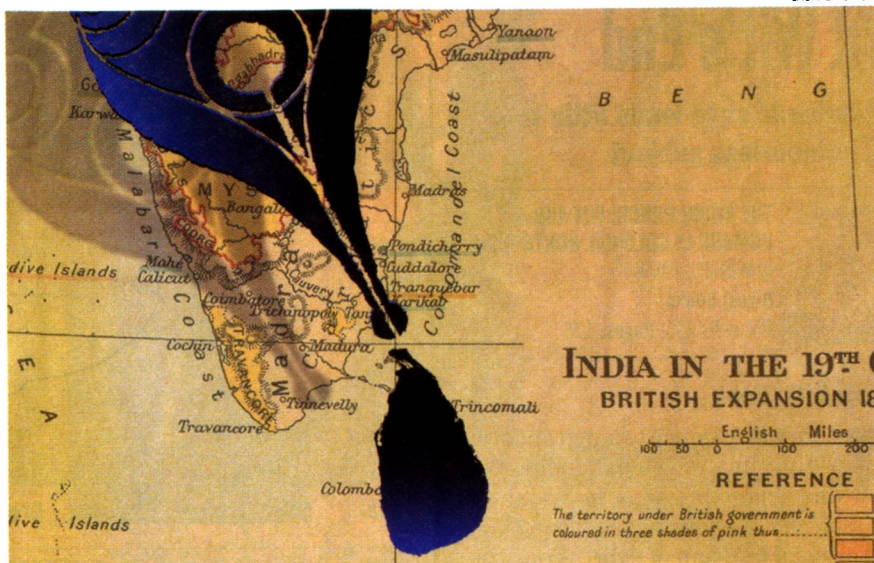


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A gutsy heroine battles a traumatic past and an uncertain future in this novel set in the war-torn landscape of Sri Lanka



SERPENT IN PARADISE

by JULIAN WEST

Atlantic Books

Price: £7.99

Pages: 339

■ By Bunny Suraiya

There are two surprises regarding nomenclature here. The first is that the author is a woman. The second is that despite the title being a cliché, its meaning is obscure. Paradise is obviously war-torn Sri Lanka, though the country is never mentioned, referred to instead as "the island", perhaps in an attempt to universalise it as a landscape of the imagination rather than a place with geographical boundaries.

But who or what is the Serpent? Is it the army, the police or the rebels—or all of the above? Is it the local people, invariably described as leering, sexually-obsessed and "rice-bellied"? Is it the graft and corruption that are rife in the island? Is it the voodoo and shamanism that run like a dark undercurrent beneath quotidian actions? Is it Cyclone Sita, the Wagnerian backdrop against which the many strings of the narrative get neatly tied up? It's impossible to be sure. What the reader can be sure of, however, is that there never was a more anguished, more beautiful

or gutsier heroine than Eva, brown of skin and green of eye, the mixed-race protagonist of a tale of self-discovery in a time of turmoil.

Eva is an internationally acclaimed photo-journalist, whose intelligence is unquestioned (as a child she was known to ask 'bright' questions such as "who made God?"). She has returned to the island not only to photograph its bloody and brutalising civil war, but also to trace her own family history, with its own brutalities which have left her scarred with the inability to love. She does indeed acquire a native lover, Navahiru, and much is made of his dusky beauty, "a flash of white teeth in a dark jungle pool", an image that recurs several times when he is mentioned. But mysteriously, the beautiful Navahiru is taken away and killed. Why? By whom? There is a hint that he is removed at the instigation of Carl, an American reporter who falls in love with Eva. Carl is humourless, has a sterile apartment unsullied by books and is into kinky sex involving bondage and whipping. Could Eva love such a man? Alas, reader, she could. Carl removes the scars of her traumatised childhood and teaches her to love, promising to take her away from the island which by this time they are both desperate to leave. So is the reader. ■